

Beauty Is All You Need

Data visualization as a business tool

Sara Mesquita

Porto, May 5th, **Data Makers Fest**

"How" became easy overnight. **"What"** and **"Why"** is as difficult as it ever was.

Format exhaustion



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Do not show me just the numbers

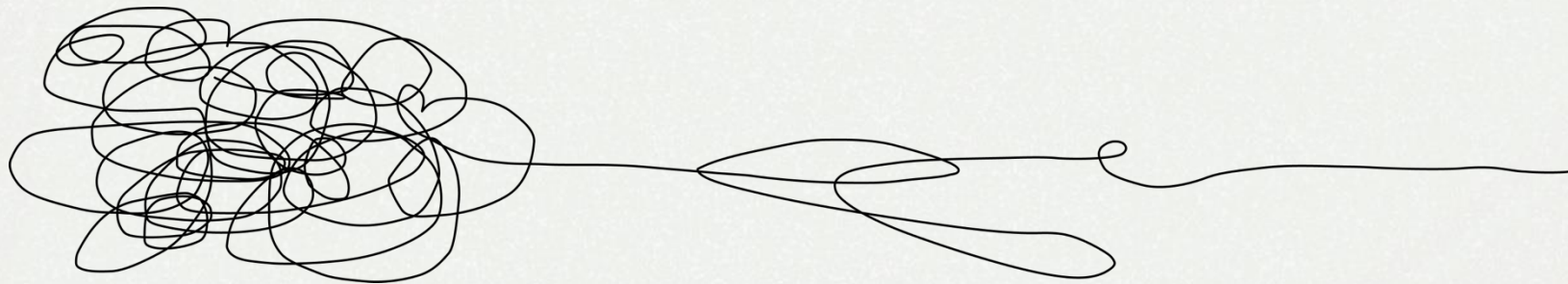


We don't need more data,
we need new ways to **experience it.**

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Complexity

Clarity



Complexity is not in the data, but in the relationships it represents. When we smooth it away, we make the world easier to read, but harder to understand. To see what surrounds us, we must move through that complexity, not reduce it. There is structure in it. And there is beauty.

A single bird is simple.

A flock is something else.

Form Follows Function

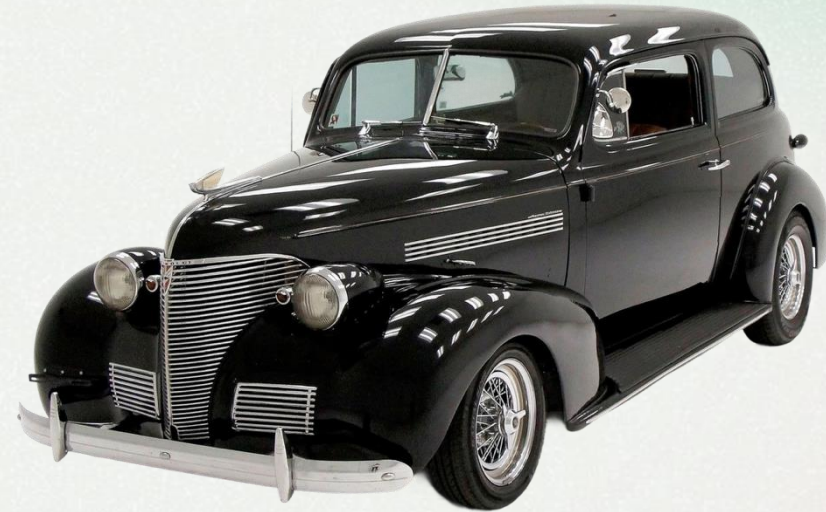


*"(...) we are just on the threshold of creating a new world on top of our modern industrial efficiency, a world in which it is possible through the much criticized machines to **replace the beauty that the machines originally displaced.**" (1927)*

Form Follows Function



1927 Ford Model T



1930s Chevrolet

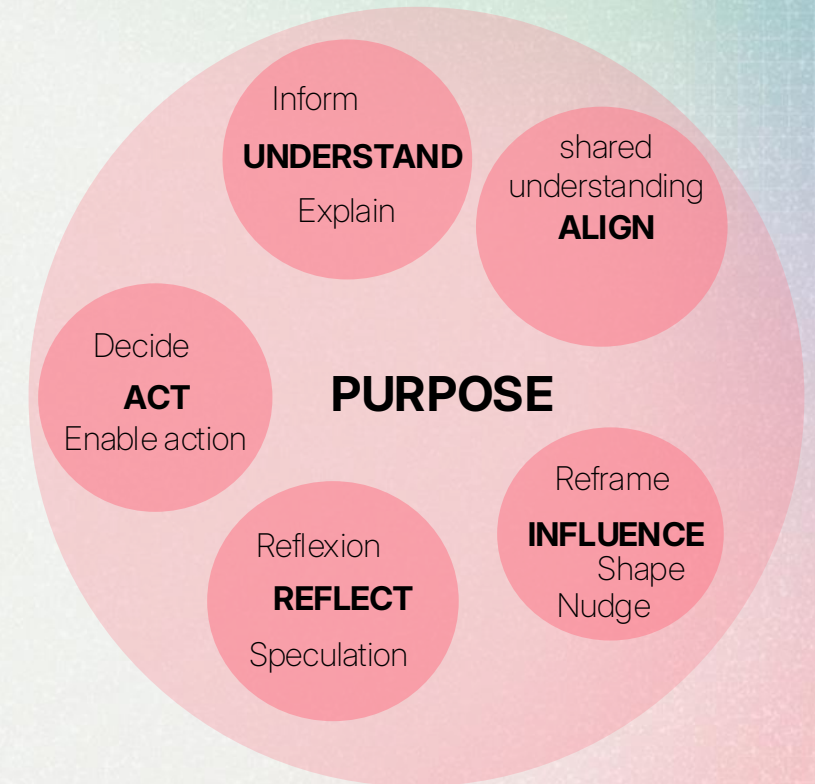
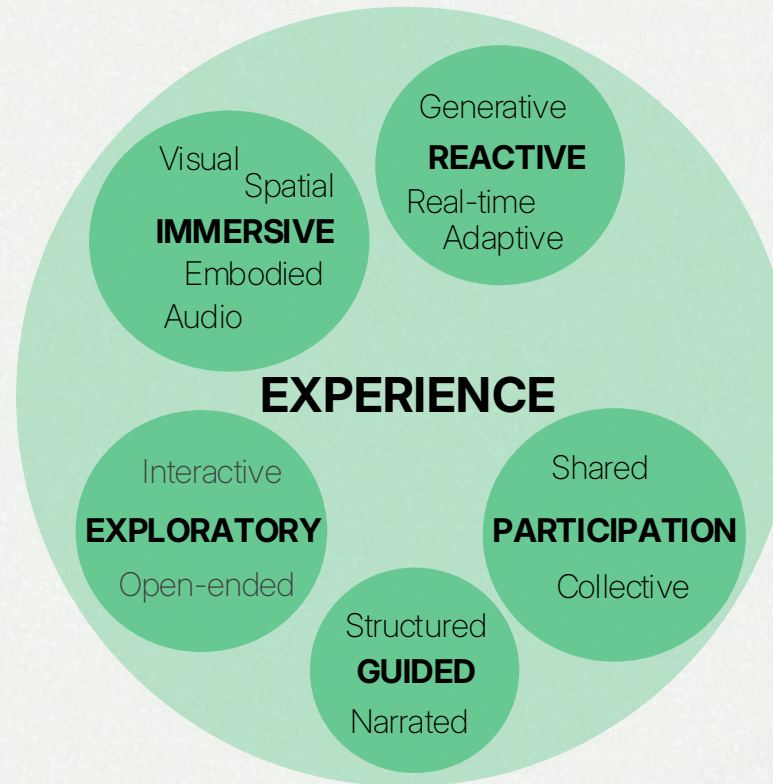
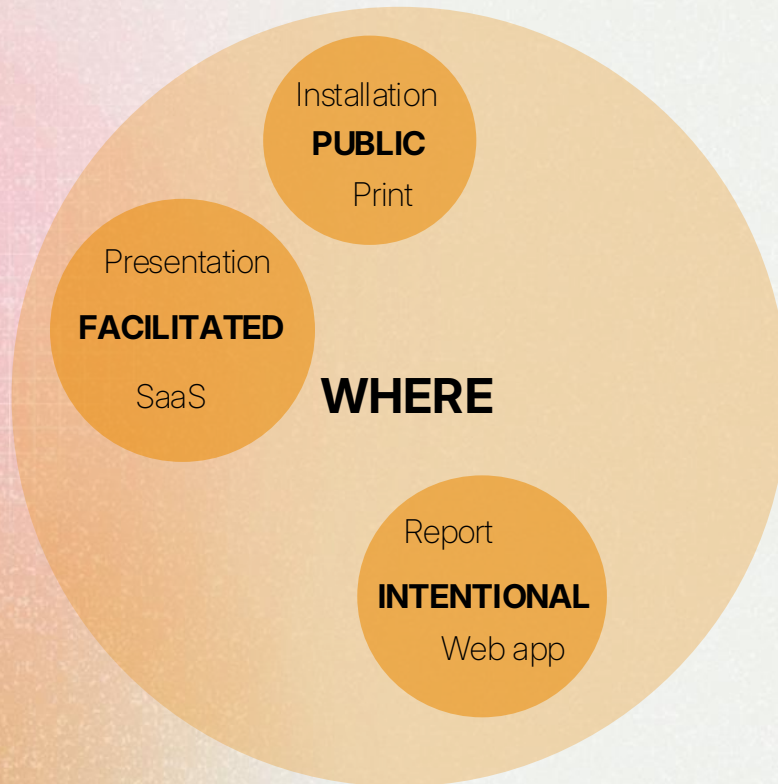
Beauty is what makes us stay.

Long enough to **notice**.

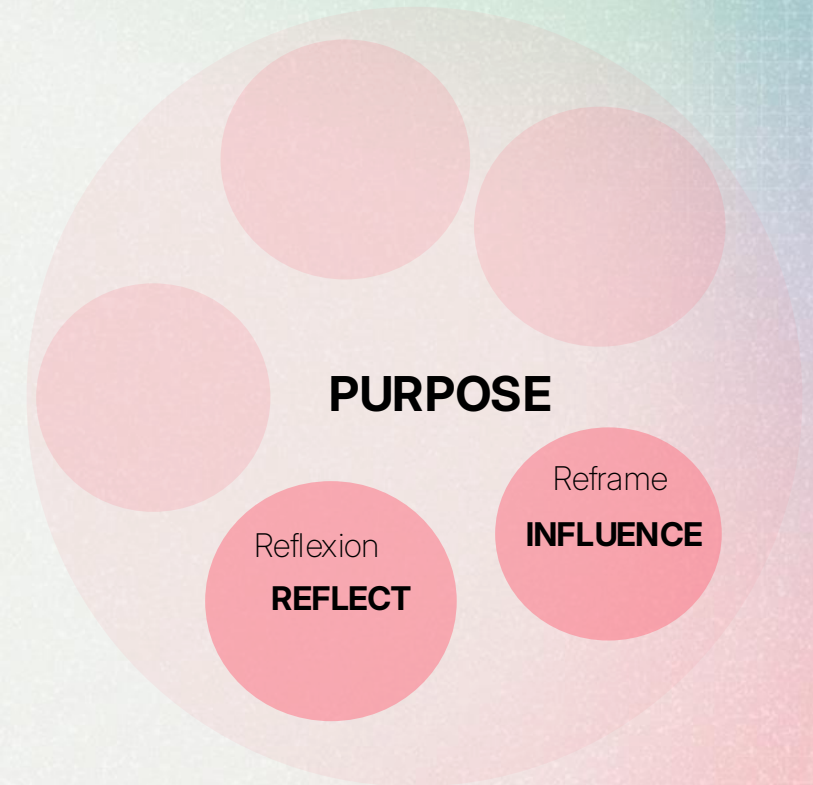
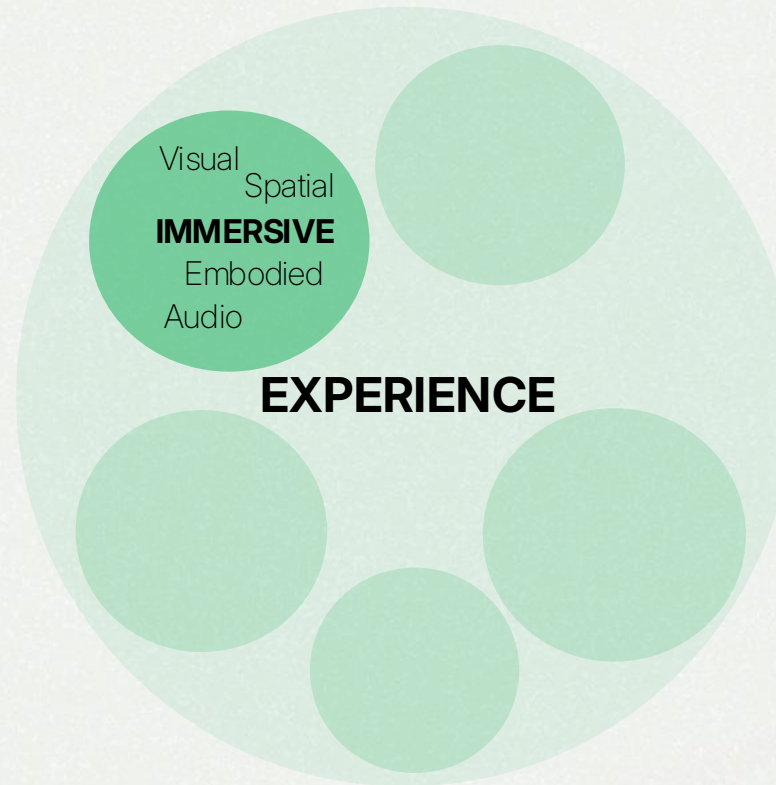
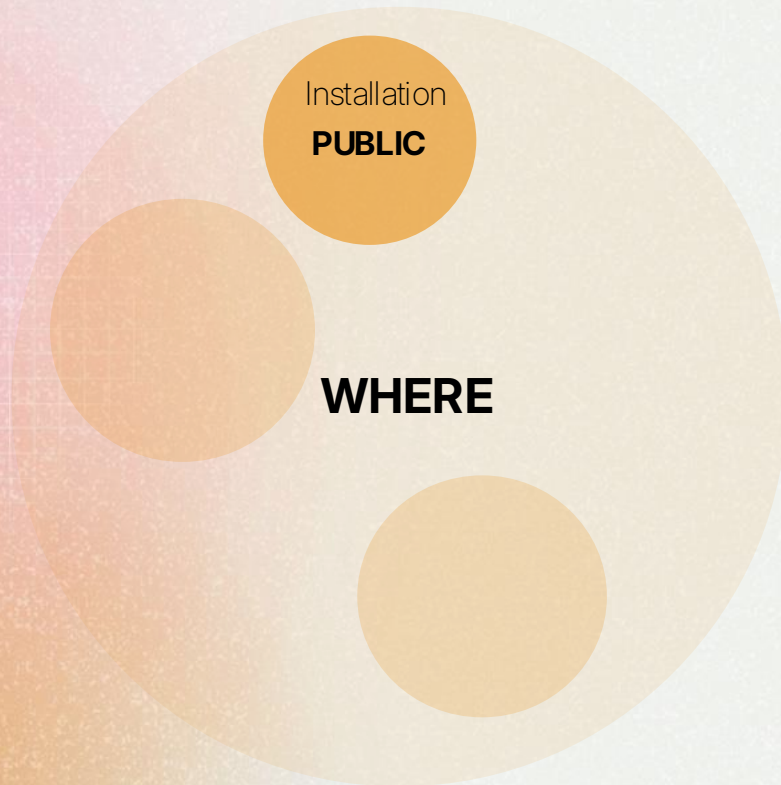
Long enough to **question**.

Long enough for **action** to follow.

Where. How. Why.



Where. How. Why.



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Build change through data

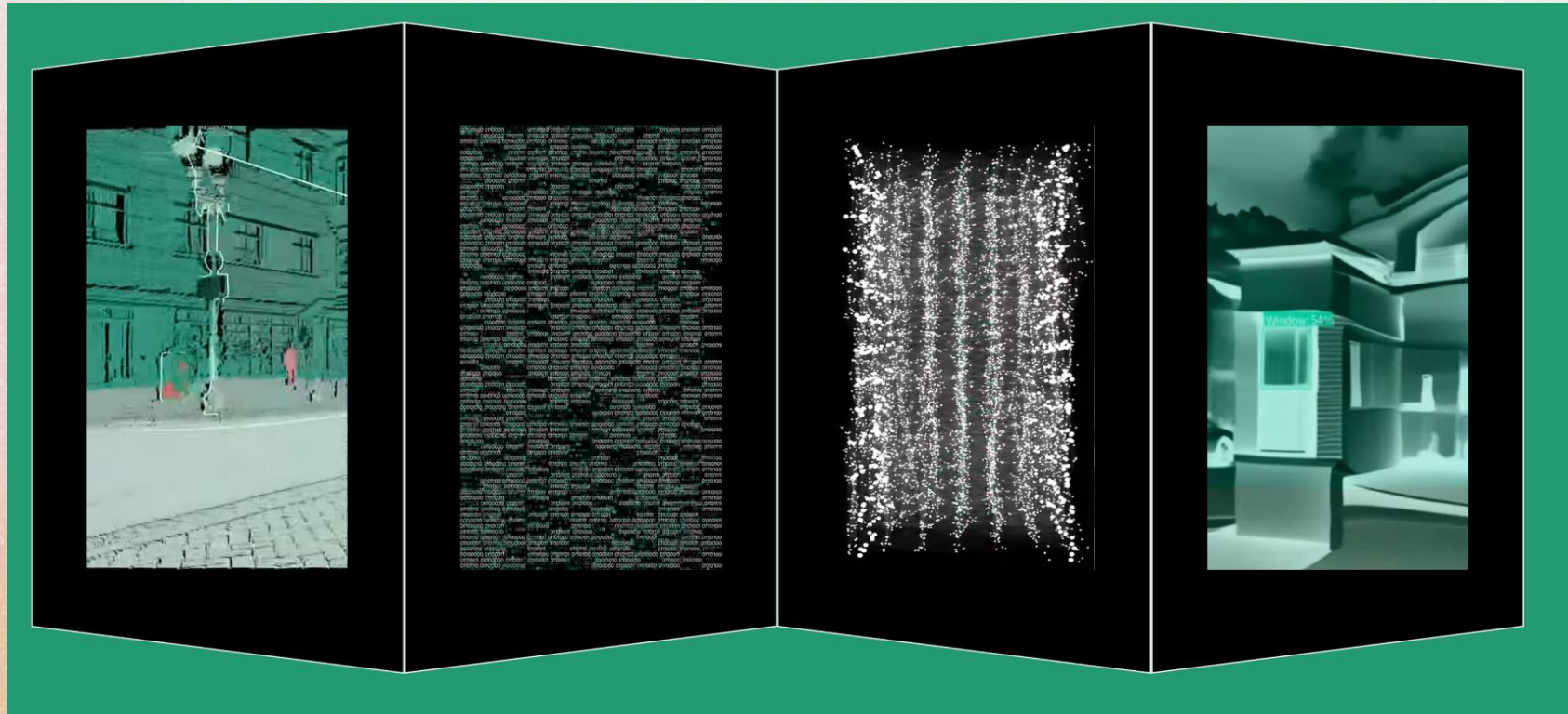


**CIVIC DESIGN
DATA LAB**
MIT

"Unboxed City: critical explorations of [ai] and cities"

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Build change through data



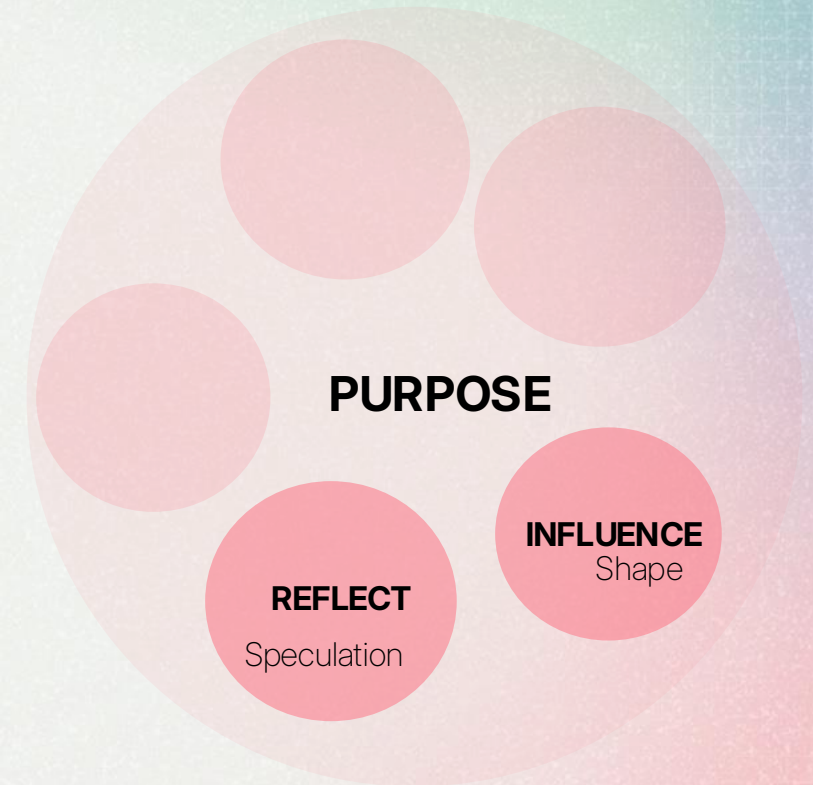
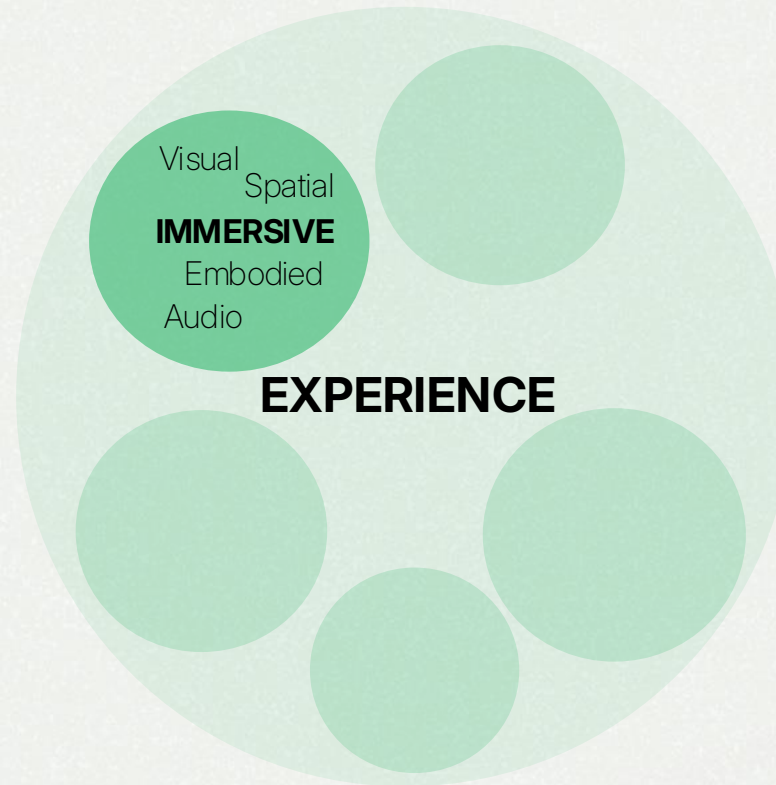
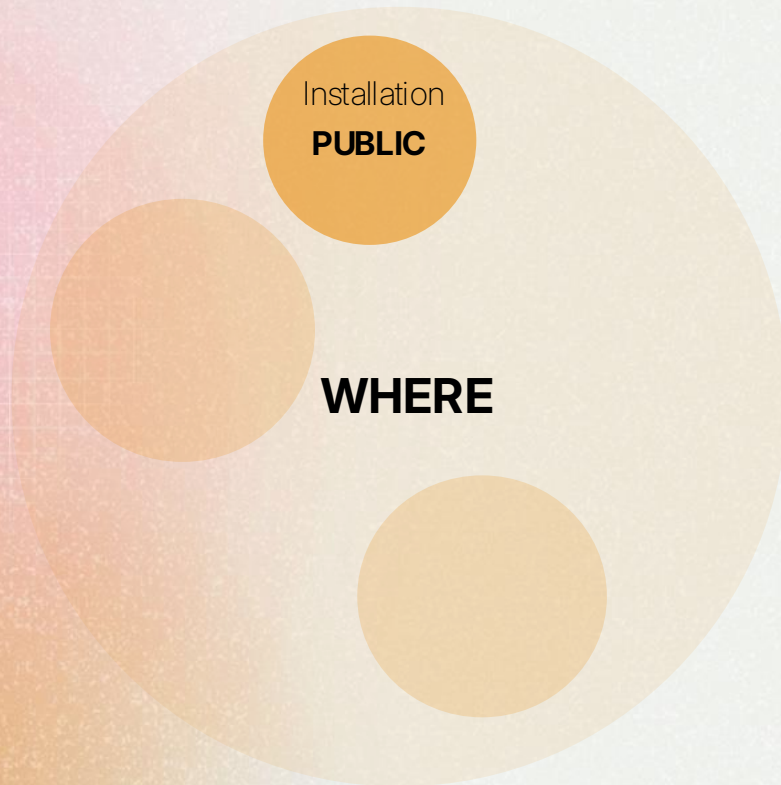
**CIVIC DESIGN
DATA LAB**



"Unboxed City: critical explorations of [ai] and cities"

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Where. How. Why.



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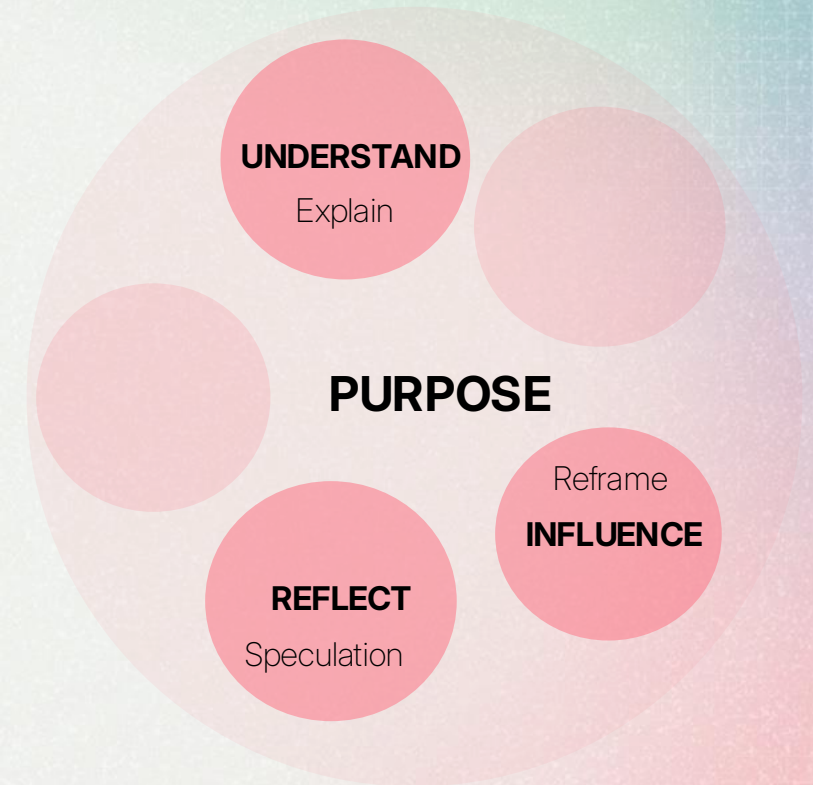
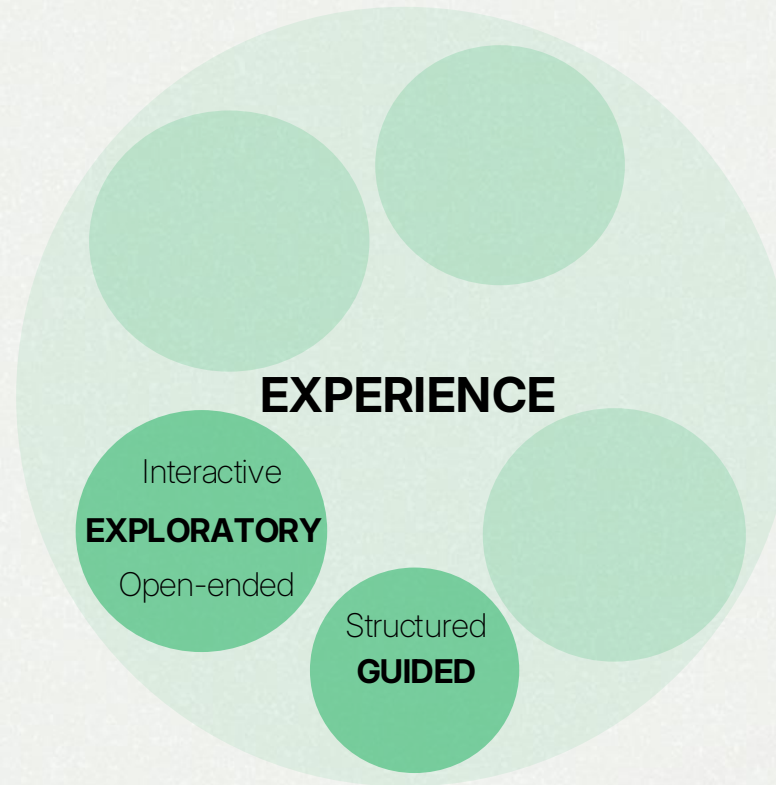
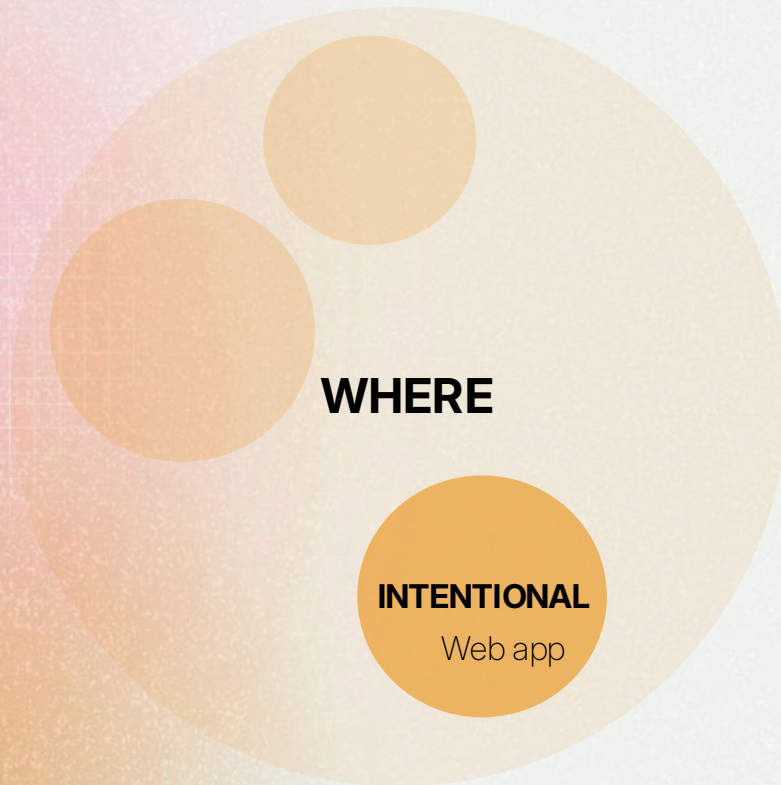
Refik Anadol



Dataland: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7jlfLu0F_mY&t=1s

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Where. How. Why.



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Documents: 25,232

Relationships: 107,030

Actors: 19,034

Graph Settings ▶

Filters ▼

Time range: 1980 - 2025



☐ Include undated events

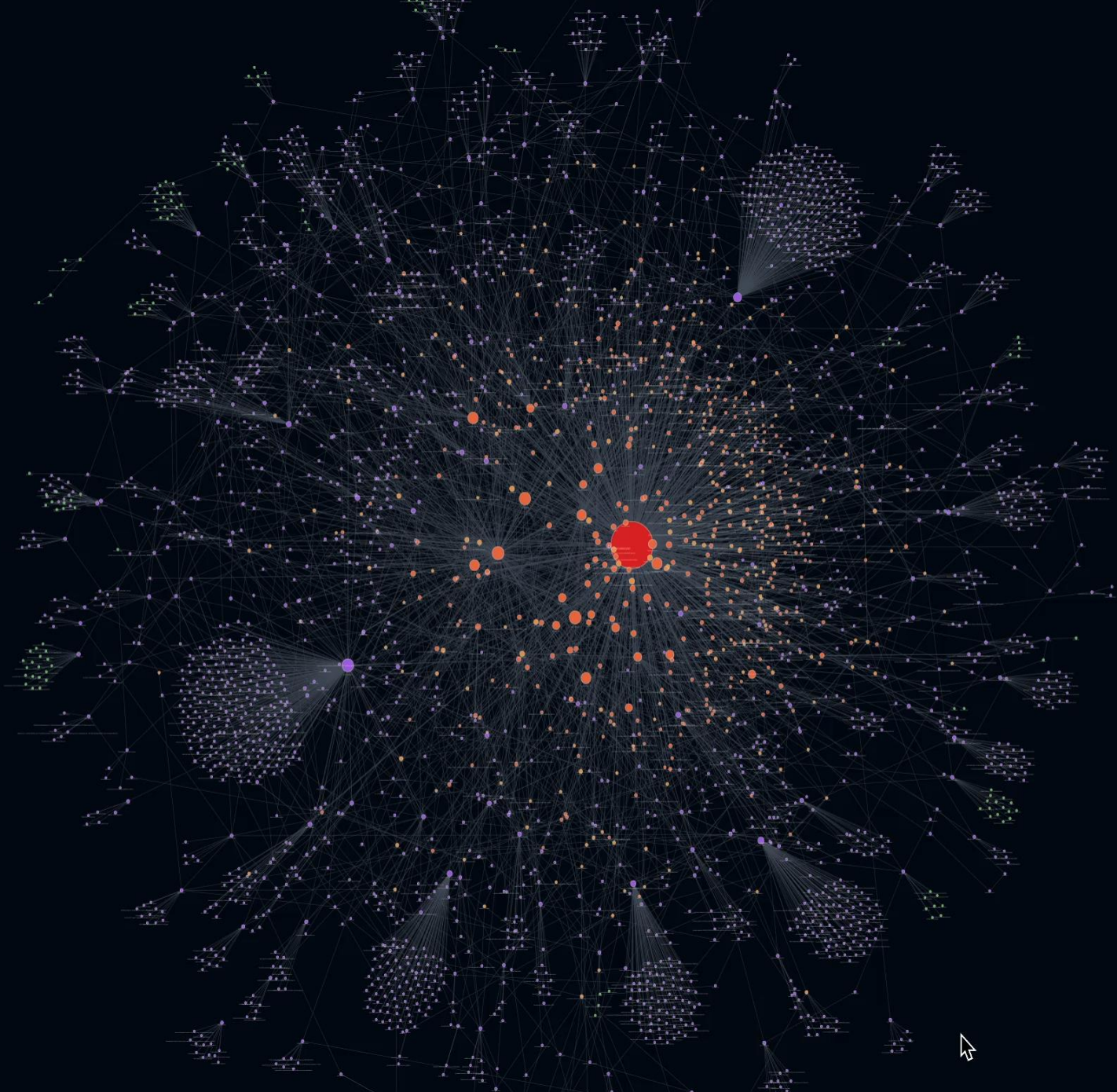
Search entities:

Keyword filter:

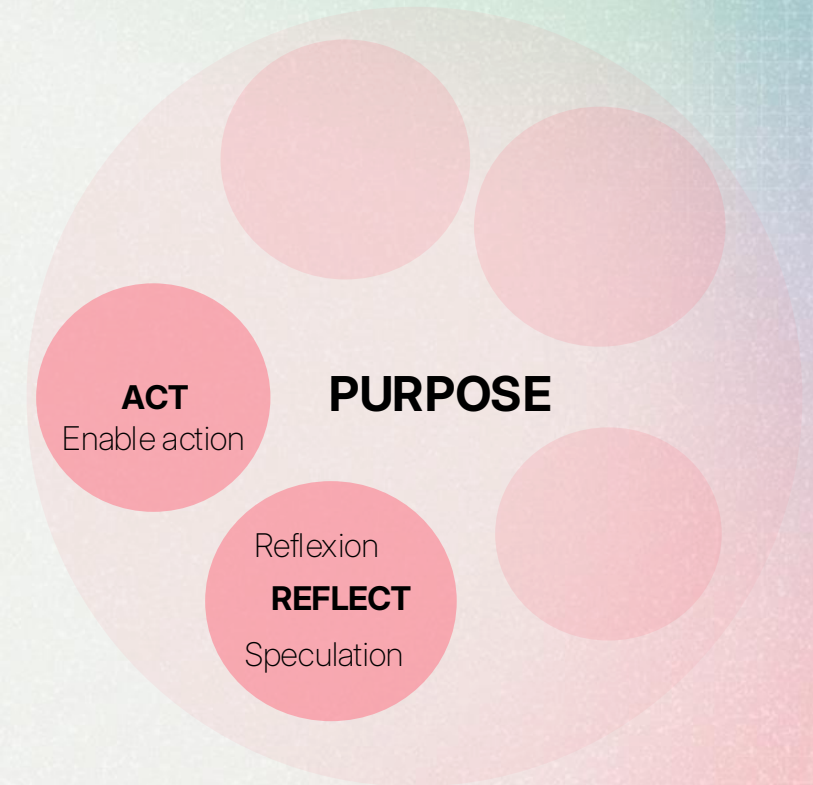
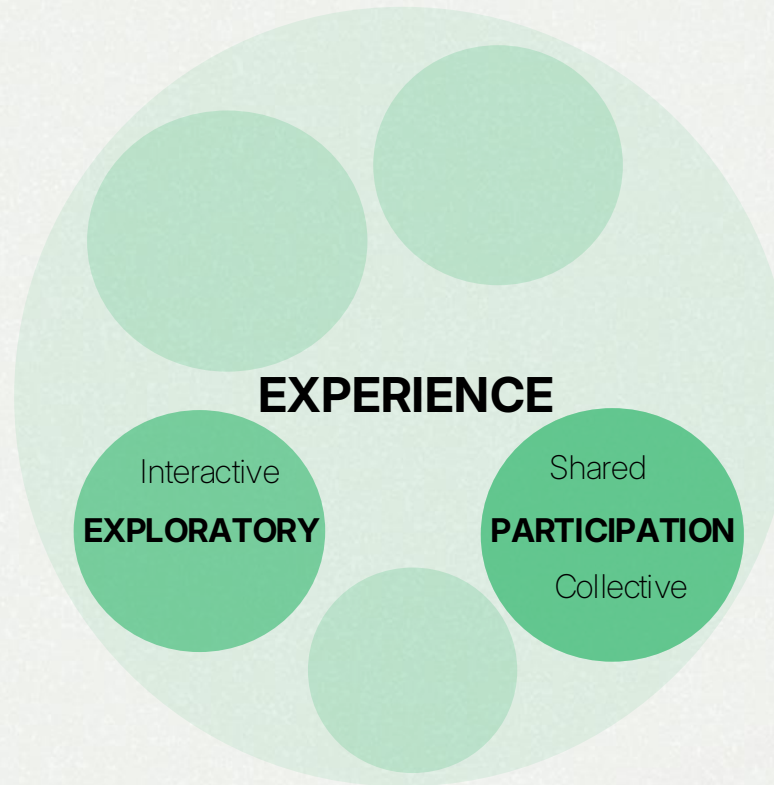
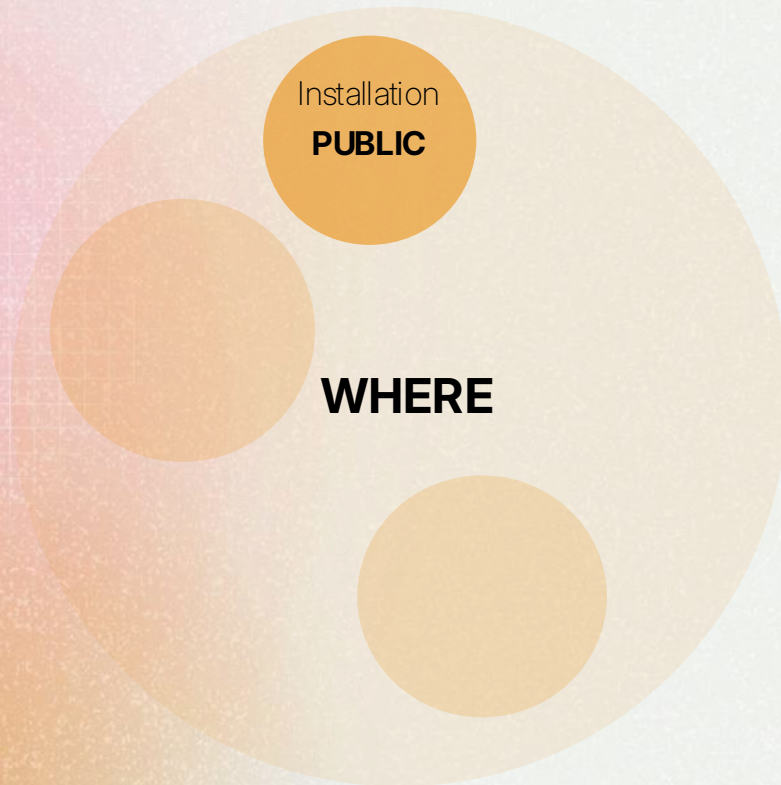
Comma-separated keywords (fuzzy match)

Content Tags ▶

Document Categories ▶

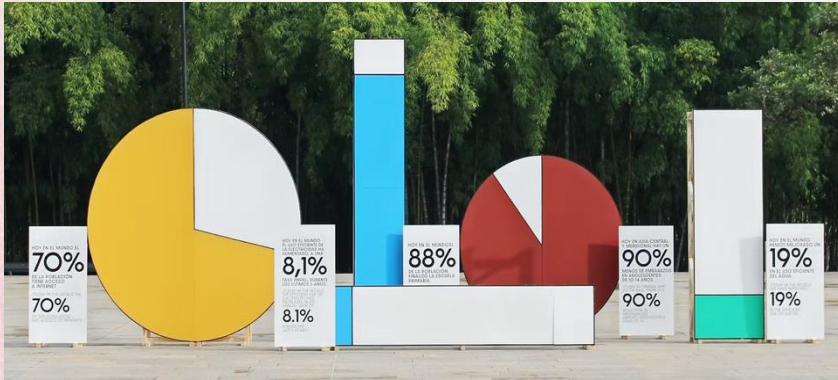


Where. How. Why.



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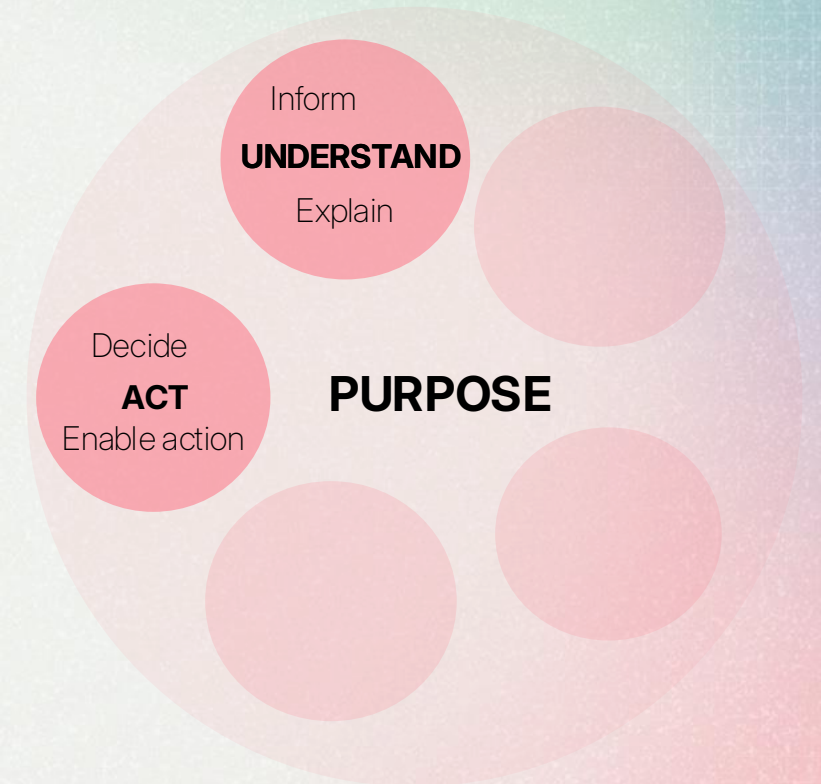
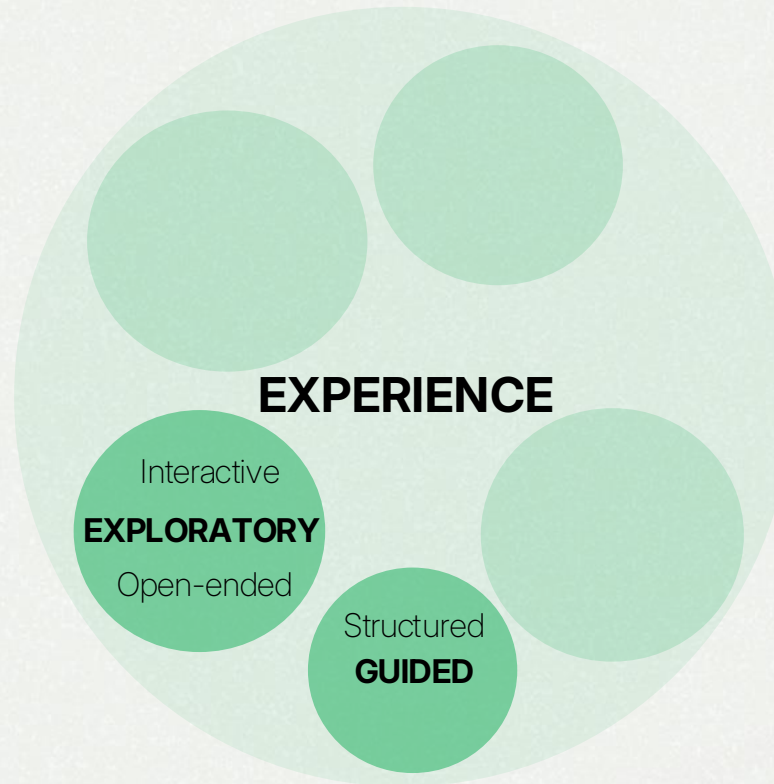
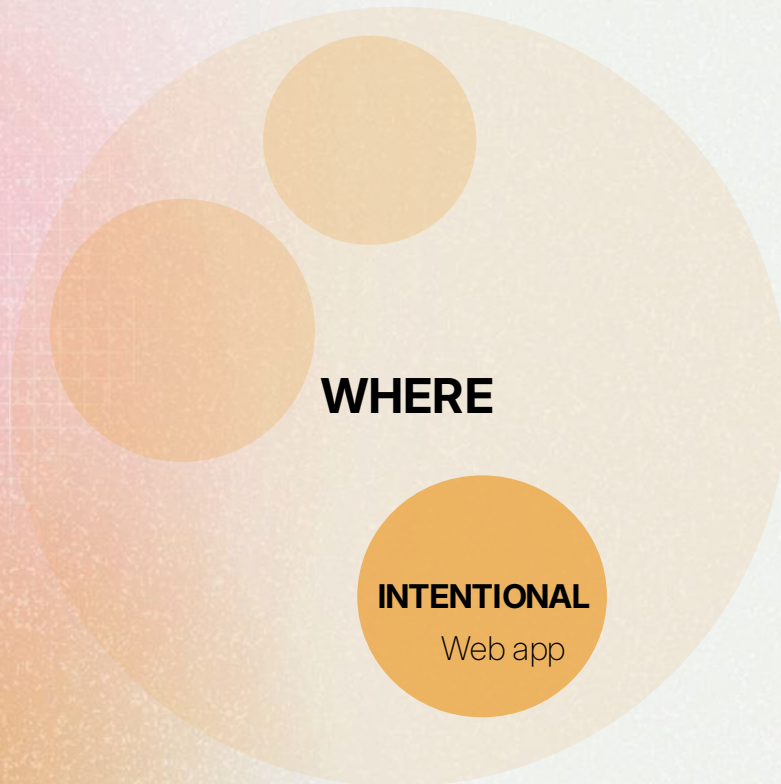
Catalysts for conversation



Jose Duarte — Easy Data Viz <https://www.easydataviz.com>

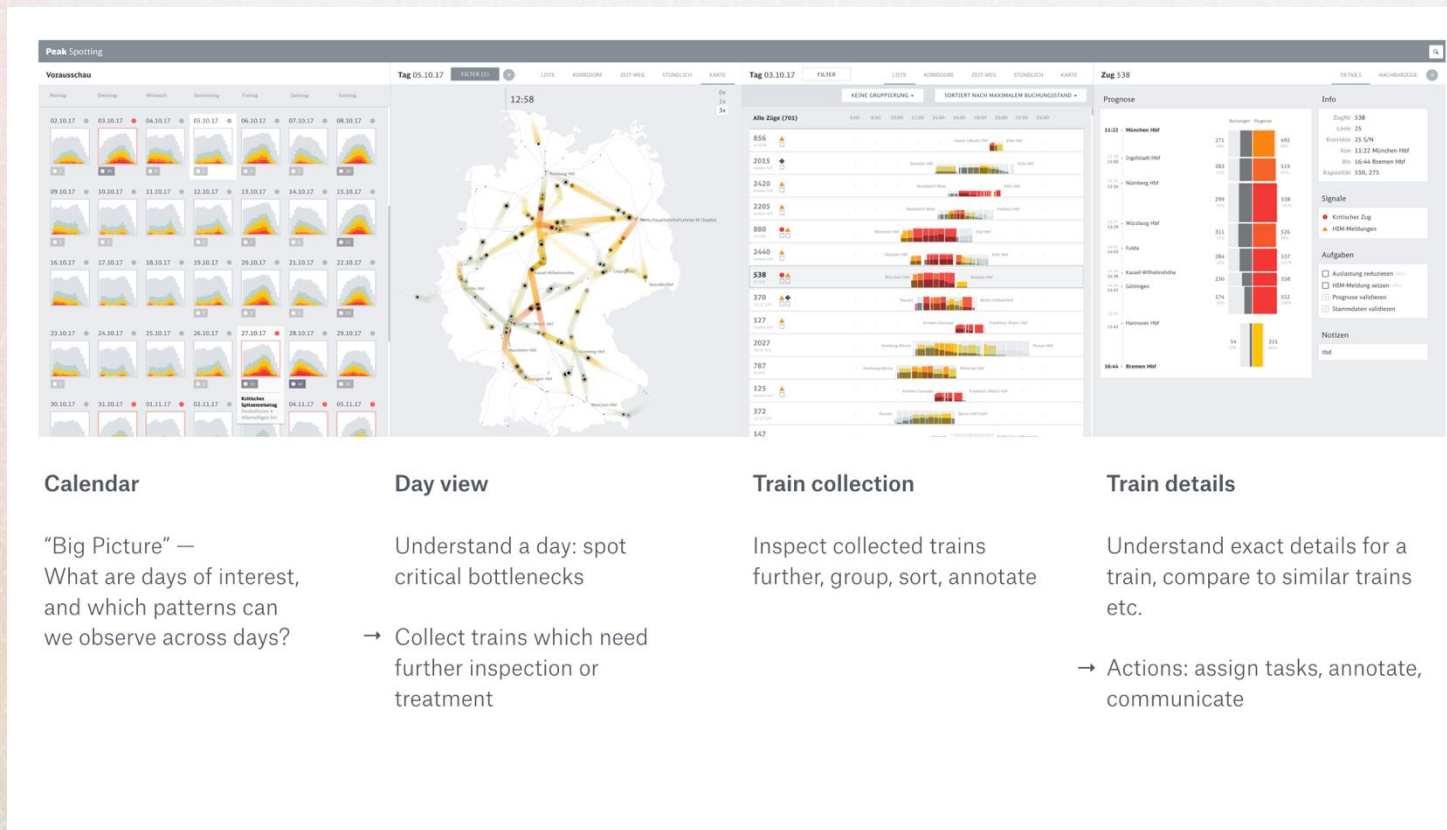
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Where. How. Why.



Peak Spotting

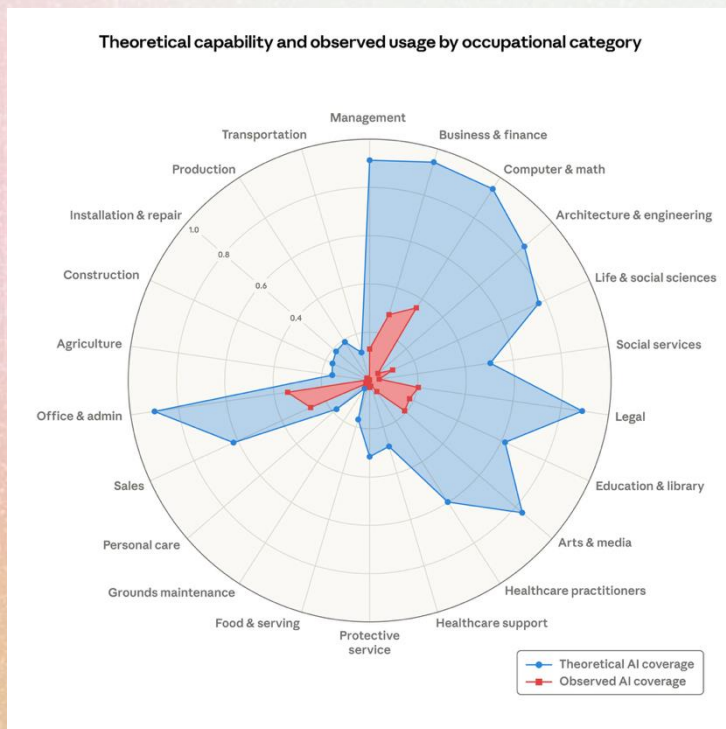
Machine learning and **visual analytics methods** to help manage the passenger loads in the German rail network (2017)



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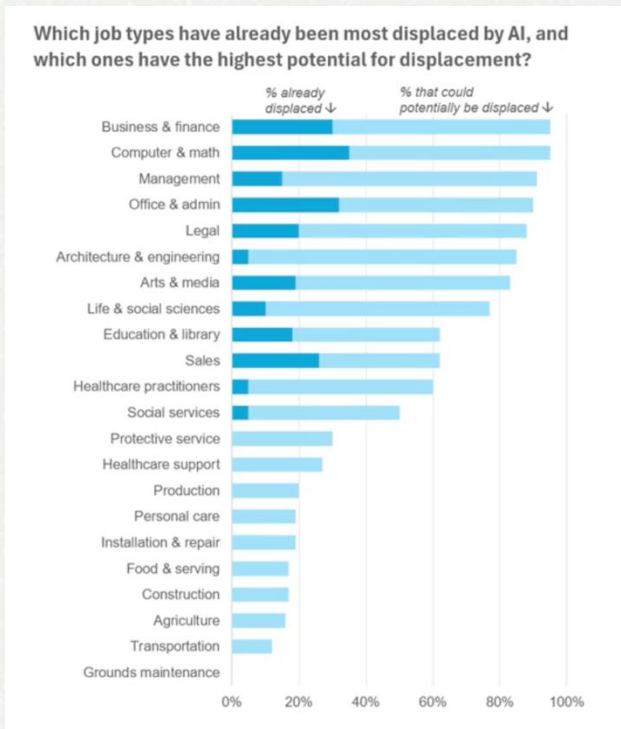
Same AI. Different results.

Original



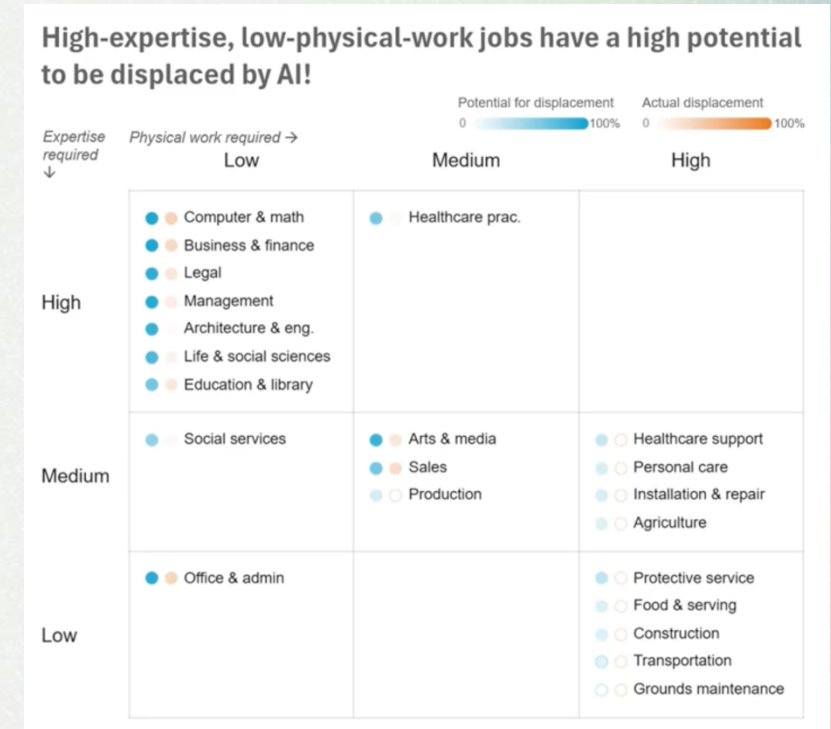
Source: <https://www.anthropic.com/research/labor-market-impacts>

Remake 1



Source: <https://bit.ly/429RAMa>

Remake 2



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If we can **build anything** with data,
what is **worth building**?



Thank you!

hello@visuallycontagious.com

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